DAAT TEVUNOT: THE RAMHAL ON CREATION, GOOD AND EVIL, AND THE SOUL

Is Evil Just the Absence of Good?

Daat Tevunot §106-110

Sefer: Daat Tevunot by Rabbi Moshe Hayim Luzzatto (the Ramhal) **Sections:** §106-110
Shiur: Part of Dayan Daniel Kada's series on Daat Tevunot, Thursday 2 March 2023

These notes are based on an automatic transcript of the recording.

Recap: emanations and the question of evil

The class opened with a question about the Midrash that every blade of grass has a force above it telling it to grow. The Rabbi reminded everyone of the difference between nature and man. In nature the emanation starts above and comes down. With humans, the energy starts here: our choices create ripple effects above, positive or negative.

Then he set out where we stand. Man's task in this section is to perfect himself by removing evil, like the Midrash of chipping away at the rock until God removes it. Evil is a novelty, since God is good. The Neshamah suggested a stream of good and a stream of bad, and the Sekhel rejected it. The verse says "oseh shalom uvore ra": with peace there is asiyah, full and active making; evil is only allowed to exist.

§106-107: evil is withdrawal

How does this allowing happen? The Ramhal brings verses about God turning His face: "You hid Your face, I was confounded" (Tehillim 30), and "I will hide My face from them and they will be consumed" (Devarim 31). The good Hashem makes. The bad is only a withdrawal of the emanation, a lot or a little.

The key point: the opposite of complete good is not complete bad. "The opposite of complete good is nothingness." If the shefa is fully present, you have full creation and full good. If it is completely cut off, nothing exists at all. If it is reduced only partly, the thing exists but is lacking.

The Ramhal's example is a child being born. With the full emanation of life and peace, the baby is born healthy, "two ears, two eyes, normal brain". With no emanation at all, the baby would not live. With a reduced emanation, he will be ill and live a difficult life. The Rabbi used the image of a dial: 99% on and the result is almost perfect with a small defect; 1% on and the result is seriously lacking. So there are not two emanations, one good and one bad. There is one emanation, and evil is the knob being turned down.

Nothingness and punishment

A participant asked: if a total withdrawal means nothing remains, does someone like Hitler simply cease to exist? Where is his punishment? The Rabbi answered that the greatest punishment is nothingness, to cease to exist. Perhaps, as discussed before, there is just enough awareness to know you do not exist.

He added that eternal damnation is not a Jewish concept. Hashem is good. However great a person's crimes, they are finite, and they do not justify billions of years of punishment. "The idea of punishment doesn't exist in Torah. There's no such thing as punishment. There's consequences."

Two kinds of evil

Another participant found it hard: if God could create only good, why is there so much evil? The Rabbi answered that of course there is evil in the world, and God created it, indirectly. He distinguished two kinds:

- Evil in nature, such as the earthquake in Turkey. There is a shefa that sustains that region. If it were cut off completely, it would simply not exist. Instead it was severely reduced, and that allowed the earthquake to happen.
- Evil done by human beings. Our bodies are created through hester, withdrawal, so even the strongest and most perfect person still has bad impulses within him.

He gave an analogy, improved by a participant. I can harm you by punching you; that is direct. Or I can be feeding you every day and stop; you become hungry and suffer, though I did nothing active to you. I simply stopped giving the good. That is how God's relationship to evil works: everything that comes down is good energy, and when the knob is turned, the result is bad.

Asked whether withdrawal might lead to random results rather than bad ones, he said no: "Hester equals bad." The more energy is withdrawn, the more bad there is; it is a direct correlation. He noted that hester has two meanings: God hiding Himself, and concealment by withdrawal, which is the meaning here. "Hester of goodness" is a contradiction in terms, an oxymoron. A participant added that a person's own decline can cause further reduction, and the Rabbi agreed: it can become a vicious circle.

§109-110: bad is the loss of good

The Neshamah asks (§109) for the second explanation that was promised. The Sekhel answers (§110): when we look carefully at the world, we find that all bad is really only the loss of good. Define every good and its boundaries, and then every bad, and you will see that each bad is the absence of some good.

The Rabbi linked this to a well known yeshiva question. Hashem created day and night. Is night a creation of its own, or is it simply what happens when there is no sun? The darkness is the same either way, but the question has halachic implications too. The Ramhal's position is that all bad, like night, is the absence of the good. The Rabbi stressed that this is not a separate answer but another way of seeing the first: there is no new emanation of bad, only the knob that decides how much good comes through.

What comes next

The remaining problem was raised for the next class. Withdrawal explains why things are defective: a person born ill, an earthquake. But how can there be things that are actively bad, like a harmful virus?

Someone also asked about the moon, which shines only by reflecting the sun. The Rabbi said this touches one of the secrets of the Kabbalah: the sun and moon were meant to be equal, and the prophecy for the future is that "the light of the moon will be like the light of the sun." Then there will be no reflection that is merely the absence of light, but full emanation, all good, with no hester.

The next class was set for the following Thursday, as there was no class on Monday because of Taanit Esther.

Summary

- Evil is not a separate emanation but a withdrawal of the one good emanation, like turning down a dial.
- The opposite of complete good is not complete evil but nothingness; total withdrawal means non-existence.
- There is no eternal damnation in Torah, only consequences; the greatest consequence is ceasing to exist.
- Natural evil comes from reduced shefa; human evil is possible because the body itself comes from hester.
- §110: all bad is the loss of a good, as night is the absence of day.

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